SMACCs (Erasmus Mundus, Smart Cities and Communities): Submission Pack

Scholarship deadline 1 Feb 2027 (E2). Submit by 25 Jan. ICT specialisation (International Hellenic University)

0. Submission readiness (Phase 8, 8 Nov 2026)

Question	Answer
Can it be submitted today?	**No.** Every SMACCs fact is E2 (smaccs.eu cannot be opened from this session), and the references and HR facts are missing
Drafted: rewrite in your own words	Motivation letter for the ICT path at International Hellenic University (section 4); path strategy (section 3); interview strategy (section 8); `06_FINAL_CV/CV_Europe_Academic` (needs HR facts)
Official requirements used	From smaccs.eu (E2): - **Admission:** bachelor's in engineering or science; English by test or prior English-medium instruction; global merit score (degree content, study success, motivation letter, 2 references with at least 1 academic, **work experience**, R&D, English). - **Scholarship:** €1,400/month for up to 24 months plus tuition waiver; at most 10% per nationality; Ethiopia is covered by the regular EMJM and NDICI (Heading 6) categories (inference: confirm)
You must provide	1. HR letters (for the CV and the work-experience score). 2. **2 signed references, at least 1 academic** (final-project supervisor, plus the SantimPay manager). 3. **DTU letter confirming English as the medium of instruction** (registrar request). 4. Transcript and degree scans; passport. 5. Your path choice plus 2 alternatives
Verify in your browser (E2)	The Application, Instructions, Deadlines and Scholarships pages: the deadline, the document formats, whether prior English-medium instruction is accepted from Ethiopia, and the scholarship categories
Exact portal link	https://www.smaccs.eu/practical/application/ (E2)
Deadline	**1 Feb 2027** for scholarship applicants (85 days); your target **25 Jan 2027** (E2). Interviews 7–18 Apr; results by 9 May
Final checks	The 8 checks in section 9

Nothing is submitted, signed, sent or paid for you.

Evidence:

- **E1:** verified on the official site
- **E2:** search-indexed official page, not opened from this session (confirm in your browser)

smaccs.eu cannot be opened from this session, so every SMACCs fact is E2.

1. Official links (E2)

Purpose	URL
Programme home	https://www.smaccs.eu/
Application (how and where to apply)	https://www.smaccs.eu/practical/application/
Instructions (documents, formats)	https://www.smaccs.eu/admissions/instructions/
Admission criteria	https://www.smaccs.eu/admissions/admission-criteria/
Deadlines	https://www.smaccs.eu/admissions/deadlines/
Scholarships	https://www.smaccs.eu/practical/scholarships/
Fees	https://www.smaccs.eu/admissions/fees/
FAQ	https://www.smaccs.eu/faq/

2. Eligibility and scholarship facts (checked)

Question	Answer	Source (E2)
Programme	2-year joint MSc, 120 ECTS; 3 semesters of courses + a thesis semester; at least one Summer School and one Winter School	smaccs.eu/the-programme/programme-structure
Universities and paths	Semesters 1 and 3: **University of Vaasa (Finland)** and **University of the Basque Country UPV/EHU, Bilbao (Spain)**, order depending on the path. Semester 2: **University of Mons (Belgium)** or **International Hellenic University, Thessaloniki (Greece)**. You choose a preferred path + two alternatives **when you apply**	…/programme-structure/mobility
Specialisations	Sustainable Urban Planning, Energy and Transport (UMONS); **Information and Communication Technologies (IHU)**; Energy Efficiency in Buildings (UPV/EHU); Smart Grid Solutions (UWASA). You earn the specialisation where you complete 60 ECTS (one semester + thesis)	…/programme-structure
Eligibility	Bachelor’s in engineering or science; other degrees reviewed case by case. **English proven by a standardised test or by prior instruction in English**	smaccs.eu/faq, /admissions/admission-criteria
Selection	Ranked by a **global merit score** built from degree content, study success, motivation letter, references (2, at least 1 academic), **work experience**, R&D experience/publications, English proficiency. Applicants above a minimum threshold are admissible (at least as self-funded)	/admissions/admission-criteria, /faq

Question	Answer	Source (E2)
Interview	For the best admissible applicants, **7–18 April 2027**	/admissions/deadlines
Scholarships	**95** Erasmus Mundus scholarships across four intakes (Sept 2024, 2025, 2026, 2027). The per-intake number is not published. **35** of the 95 are “Heading 6” additional scholarships for students from third countries not associated to the programme: 31 funded by NDICI–Global Europe, 4 by IPA III	/practical/scholarships
Which categories include Ethiopia	**Regular EMJM scholarships** (open to all nationalities) **and** the **NDICI-funded Heading 6 scholarships** (third countries not associated to the programme). IPA III (4 places) is for pre-accession countries, not Ethiopia. No regional sub-quota is published	/practical/scholarships (inference from the categories: confirm by e-mail if you want certainty)
Nationality limit	No more than **10%** of all scholarships awarded during the project may go to one nationality	/practical/scholarships
Amount	**€1,400 per month for up to 24 months + tuition waived**	/admissions/fees, student agreement
Insurance	Consortium pays health insurance (scholarship and self-funded students)	/faq
Not covered	Mobility travel and accommodation; Summer/Winter School travel and lodging; visa and residence-permit fees; graduation costs; university language courses. These must come out of the €1,400 a month	/admissions/fees, student agreement
Self-funded tuition	€8,000 per year (€16,000 in total) for third-country students	/admissions/fees
Deadlines	**Scholarship applicants: 1 Feb 2027.** Self-funded: 30 Apr 2027 (visa needed) / 8 Jun 2027. Scholarship results by **9 May 2027**	/admissions/deadlines
Cohort size	At most 40 students	/faq

3. Fit and path choice

Path to choose:

- **ICT specialisation:** Semester 2 at IHU, Thessaloniki, with the thesis at IHU.
- **Alternatives:** paths whose Semester 2 is at Mons, or a thesis at Vaasa (Smart Grid Solutions, if its monitoring and data side suits you).

Smart-city theme	Genuine link to your work (only if confirmed)	What you must not claim
Digital infrastructure	You operate Linux servers, networks and deployment pipelines for payment services	Designing city-wide networks
Smart urban services	Digital payments are city services: merchants, schools, transport fares, utility bills. School-fee payments are part of SantimPay's services	Running smart-city projects
Intelligent systems	Monitoring and alerting on live services; interest in anomaly detection	AI expertise (you have one introductory AI course, grade B)
Cybersecurity	Security controls at Kifiya (IAM/MFA, WAF, PAM/DAM: only those you configured yourself); Computer Security course (B)	Security research
Data-driven public services	Transaction and monitoring data that show how a service is used and when it fails	Public-sector data projects
Technology infrastructure	Reliability, automation and incident response	–
Sustainable digital transformation	Ethiopia's move from cash to digital payments; energy cost of running infrastructure	Energy-engineering knowledge

Weaknesses:

- Grades (study success) and the lack of R&D experience or publications.

Strengths:

- Relevant degree content (CS → ICT track).
- Work experience on live public-facing digital services.
- An English-taught degree.

4. Written response: motivation letter (complete draft; rewrite in your own words)

> **Subject: Application to the Erasmus Mundus Joint Master in Smart Cities and Communities (SMACCs), September 2027, ICT specialisation**
>
> Dear SMACCs Selection Committee,
>
> In Addis Ababa, one of Africa's fastest-growing cities, more and more everyday transactions now pass through digital systems: a shopkeeper accepting a QR payment, a parent paying school fees from a phone, a bank settling payments for thousands of merchants. Since [⏳ year] I have worked on the infrastructure behind such services at SantimPay, a payments company that runs POS, QR, school-payment and payment-gateway services with Ethiopian banks [⏳ your exact role]. My work keeps these services running: I [⏳ two verified duties]. When they fail, the effect is immediately visible in the city: a merchant cannot sell, a family cannot pay.
>
> This experience convinced me that a smart city is first of all reliable, secure digital infrastructure that people can trust, and that data from these systems can make urban services better. I want to learn how to design such infrastructure for whole communities, and how to connect it to energy, mobility and public services. That is why I am applying to SMACCs, and to its Information and Communication Technologies specialisation in particular.

> **Academic preparation.** I hold a BSc in Computer Science from Debre Tabor University (2022), taught in English. My cumulative GPA is 2.62/4.00. My results improved strongly as I moved into core computing subjects: my final year was my best (3.20 by my calculation from the transcript), with A− in Advanced Programming, Compiler Design, Complexity Theory and both parts of my final-year project ([⏳ title]). I also studied Data Communication and Computer Networks, Wireless and Mobile Computing (B+), Introduction to Distributed Systems, Computer Security and Introduction to Artificial Intelligence.
>
> **Professional experience.** [⏳ Two or three sentences from the HR letters: titles, years, responsibilities.] [⏳ One concrete example: an incident, an automation or a rollout, with a real result.] [⏳ If true: one sentence on security work at Kifiya.]
>
> **Why SMACCs.** Three things attract me:
>
> 1. The mobility path lets me study smart-grid and ICT perspectives in Finland, Spain and Greece, which matches the interdisciplinary nature of the problems I see at home.
> 2. The ICT specialisation at the International Hellenic University would give me the networking, IoT and data-platform depth that my operational work lacks.
> 3. Projects with industry and the Summer and Winter Schools would train me to work in international teams on real urban problems.
>
> I would choose the path [⏳ exact path name from the application form] with my thesis at IHU, and as a thesis direction I would like to explore [⏳ e.g. resilient and secure data platforms for city payment and mobility services in fast-growing African cities].
>
> **After SMACCs.** I intend to return to Ethiopia and work on the digital infrastructure of urban services, [⏳ e.g. payment and data platforms for city transport, utilities or schools], helping to make them reliable, secure and inclusive. I would also share what I learn with engineers and students at home [⏳ only a real plan].
>
> Thank you for considering my application.
>
> Yours sincerely, [Passport name]

5. Documents and formats

Document	Format (confirm on the Instructions page)	Status
Online application with path choice + 2 alternative paths	Web form	You
CV	PDF	`06_FINAL_CV/CV_Europe_Academic` (needs HR facts)
Transcript + degree certificate	PDF scans of official documents	You (scan)
Motivation letter	PDF, 1–2 pages	Section 4
2 reference letters (at least 1 academic)	Signed, on letterhead	Drafts in `16_RECOMMENDATIONS/`
English proof	Test, **or** proof of prior instruction in English (DTU registrar letter, item 4f)	Ask SMACCs to confirm (e-mail 4)
Passport	PDF	You

6. Outstanding items

1. Confirm the facts in your browser (Application, Instructions, Deadlines).
2. HR letters, then fill the CV and the letter.

3. Two signed references (supervisor + SantimPay manager).
4. Registrar letter confirming English medium of instruction.
5. Choose the path names exactly as in the form.

7. Submission guide

1. Open the Application page and create the account.
2. Fill in your details; choose the ICT path + 2 alternatives.
3. Upload the documents in the order the form asks.
4. Tick the scholarship option.
5. **Submit by 25 Jan 2027** (deadline 1 Feb).
6. Interviews for the best applicants are held 7–18 April. Scholarship results by 9 May.

8. Interview strategy

Prepare a 3-minute self-presentation:

1. Degree → final-year improvement
2. Payment infrastructure → one real result
3. Why SMACCs + the ICT path
4. Thesis direction
5. Plan after graduation

Likely question	Outline (use real facts)
Why smart cities, given that you work in fintech?	Payments are an urban service; reliability, security and data are the core of smart-city platforms
Why the ICT specialisation and this path?	Networks, IoT and data platforms; link each semester's location to what you want to learn
What do you know about smart-city technology?	IoT sensing → networks → data platforms → services; the security and privacy risks; energy use. Read 2–3 recent smart-city case studies before April
Your grades are modest. Why should we rank you?	Upward trend, relevant A− courses, real responsibility for live services
A technical problem you solved	One incident STAR story
Teamwork across cultures	A real example with partner banks or colleagues
Can you handle three countries in two years?	Practical answers: budget from the €1,400 a month, visas, adaptability
Thesis idea	A specific, modest question; ask the panel which professor works on it

Preparation:

- 2 mock interviews with me (recorded).

- Read the IHU ICT specialisation course list once it is visible on smaccs.eu.

9. Final audit checklist

- [ ] Facts confirmed on smaccs.eu
- [ ] Path + 2 alternatives chosen
- [ ] Letter ≤ 2 pages, own words, no `[…]` left
- [ ] CV dates match the HR letters
- [ ] 2 references, at least 1 academic, signed
- [ ] English proof accepted
- [ ] Scholarship box ticked
- [ ] Submitted by 25 Jan; confirmation saved